a pocket field guide to

WILD ERRORS



how to spot & identify the numbers that pop up when the web has something to tell you

field guides to the digital wild · no. 2

made with ink & a slow connection
after RFC 9110 & RFC 2324 · by jerry gay

my sightings

- ☐ 200 (so common nobody looks twice)
- ☐ 301 ☐ 403 ☐ 503
- ☐ 404 (if you spotted one, you didn't.)
- ☐ 418 (rare!)
- ☐ _____ (more out there. go look.)

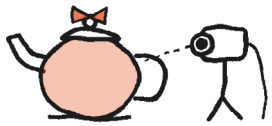
if you meet one:
4xx: check what you asked for, and whether you're allowed.
5xx: it's not you. wait, then try again.

cut along the dashes

field notes: the rarest one

april 1, 1998. someone wrote a serious-looking standard for brewing coffee over the internet. ask a teapot for coffee and it answers:

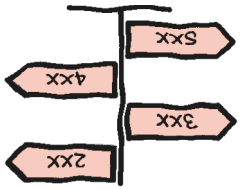
418, i'm a teapot.



in 2017, engineers tried to remove it. people protested until it stayed. today it's officially reserved: a protected species.

how to identify

every one of them carries a number. look at the first digit: it tells you the family.



2 happy. it worked.
3 migratory. it moved.
4 the problem's on your side.
5 the server tripped.

(1xx are the larvae. you'll almost never see one.)

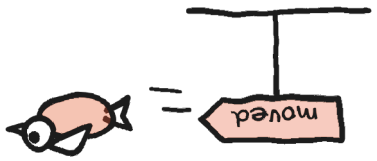
the 301

Codus migratorius

flew away and never came back. but it's polite: it leaves a note saying where it went, and your browser follows without a word.

habitat: old addresses, sites that moved to https

catch difficulty: ★☆☆☆☆
(it tells you where it went)



the 404

Codus absens

you've seen its sign a hundred times. but go looking for the page and you only find the spot where it should be. (it isn't hiding. there's just nothing there.)

habitat: links from 2009, typos

catch difficulty: ☆☆☆☆☆
(nothing to catch)



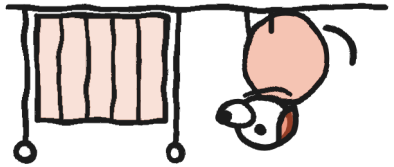
the 403

Codus prohibitus

guards the gate. its cousin the 401 asks "who are you?" the 403 knows exactly who you are. the answer is still no.

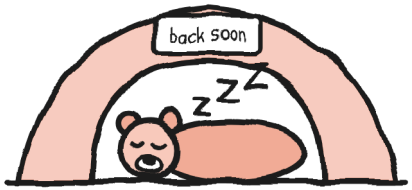
habitat: admin pages, the cookie jar

catch difficulty: don't. it's doing its job.



the 503

Codus hibernans



too tired, too busy, or out for maintenance. leave it alone and it's usually back by morning. (poking it makes it grumpier.)

habitat: launch days, the minute tickets go on sale

catch difficulty: ★★☆☆☆
(just wait)